8.1.1 DIARRHOEA

Diarrhoea is the leading cause of malnutrition and death in children under 5 years old. Diarrhoea is characterized by the frequent evacuation of liquid stools, accompanied by an excessive loss of fluid and electrolytes. Diarrhoea is the condition when there is rapid transit of intestinal contents through the small intestine, reduced enzymatic digestion of foods and decreased absorption of nutrients.

Types of diarrhoea

Diarrhoea can be acute or chronic in nature.

- **Acute diarrhoea** is an episode of recent origin. It is the condition with passage of watery stools without visible blood. Acute diarrhoea is caused by viral infection, bacterial toxins, bacterial infection, metal poisoning, side effects of drugs and structural or functional abnormalities of intestine.
- **Chronic diarrhoea** is when the duration of symptoms is longer than one month. It is characterized by frothy and acidic stools. Chronic diarrhoea is a result of long term diseases such as malabsorption syndrome, metabolic diseases, chronic deficiencies, allergy, cirrhosis of liver and carcinoma of small intestine and colon.

Causes of diarrhoea:

The causes of diarrhoea are:

- Overeating or eating of foods difficult to digest
- Viral infection (rotavirus)
- Bacterial infection (E.coli , Shigella)
- Bacterial toxins (Salmonella toxin)
- Protozoa infection (Giardia, Entamoeba histolytica)
- Malabsorption syndrome (Steatorrhea, Lactose intolerance)
- Metabolic disease (Diabetic neuropathy, Addison's disease)



DEHYDRATION

- One of the important consequences of diarrhoea is dehydration.
- Dehydration is loss of water and electrolytes from the body.
- Dehydration results in reduction in extracellular blood volume and hence a reduction in the total blood volume.
- Low blood volume is associated with hypotension and a low cardiac output.
- Severe dehydration leads to ischemic damage to the tissues and organs due to reduced supply of oxygen and nutrients.
- In severe dehydration, death may also occur.

Signs of dehydration: Inelastic and dry skin, dry lips and mouth, furred tongue, cold extremities, dizziness, weakness and anorexia



How to identify the signs of dehydration?

Skin turgor is a sign of dehydration. Skin pinch test is used to identify dehydration. Follow the steps given below:

- Pinch the skin on the back of patient's hand, lower arm or abdomen, between thumb and first finger. Do not use finger tips because it causes pain.
- Hold the skin for a few seconds and release.
- Observe how quickly the skin returns to its normal shape.
- If the skin is quick to return to normal, it is a sign that the patient is hydrated, whereas if it takes longer, the patient could be dehydrated.

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